BEYOND CHIAVARI · FREE PLANNING KIT

Backyard Party Planning Kit

Measure your yard, size your party, and plan shade, power, restrooms, and cleanup

A backyard party can feel effortless, but it takes a little math to get right. This kit starts with measuring your space and then walks through seating, shade, power, restrooms, neighbors, food, rentals, and cleanup.

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Chairs, tables, linens, tents and more across Chicagoland, on one quote.

PART 1

Yard Measuring and Party Worksheet

Sketch your yard on the back of this page and mark each item below.

PARTY DATE AND RAIN DATE

EXPECTED GUEST COUNT

TOTAL USABLE YARD LENGTH (FEET)

TOTAL USABLE YARD WIDTH (FEET)

USABLE SQUARE FOOTAGE (LENGTH X WIDTH)

PATIO OR DECK SIZE

LEVEL, DRY LAWN AREA

LOCATION OF TREES AND SHADE

LOCATION OF OUTDOOR OUTLETS

GATE OR PATH WIDTH FOR DELIVERIES

NEAREST RESTROOM TO THE PARTY

WHERE THE FOOD WILL BE SET UP

WHERE GUESTS WILL PARK

BACKUP SPACE IF IT RAINS

RENTAL COMPANY AND DELIVERY WINDOW

TOTAL BUDGET

PART 2

Space Per Guest

Rough planning numbers. Allow more room for dancing, games, or lots of kids.

Setup	Space per guest	Fits 25 guests	Fits 50 guests	Fits 100 guests
Standing cocktail party	6 to 8 sq ft	150 to 200 sq ft	300 to 400 sq ft	600 to 800 sq ft
Seated at round tables	10 to 12 sq ft	250 to 300 sq ft	500 to 600 sq ft	1,000 to 1,200 sq ft
Mixed seating and mingling	12 to 15 sq ft	300 to 375 sq ft	600 to 750 sq ft	1,200 to 1,500 sq ft
Seated with buffet and lawn games	15 to 20 sq ft	375 to 500 sq ft	750 to 1,000 sq ft	1,500 to 2,000 sq ft
Dance floor (additional)	4 to 5 sq ft per dancer	Plan 8 x 8 ft	Plan 12 x 12 ft	Plan 16 x 16 ft
Buffet or bar area (additional)	Allow 10 to 15 ft of table space	1 station	1 to 2 stations	2 to 3 stations

PART 3

Planning Timeline

6 to 8 weeks out

- [ ] Choose a date and a backup date if the weather is uncertain.
- [ ] Measure the yard and decide on the number of guests.
- [ ] Check city or village rules for tents, noise, fires, and street parking.
- [ ] Request rental quotes for tent, tables, chairs, and linens.
- [ ] Think through restroom, power, and lighting needs.
- [ ] Choose a food style: grill, catering, food truck, or potluck.

4 weeks out

- [ ] Send invitations with start and end times and parking notes.
- [ ] Book rentals and confirm delivery windows.
- [ ] Hire a caterer, bartender, or food truck if needed.
- [ ] Order a cake or desserts.
- [ ] Reserve a portable restroom if needed.
- [ ] Plan games, music, and activities.

2 weeks out

- [ ] Follow up on RSVPs.
- [ ] Notify neighbors about the party, noise, and parking.
- [ ] Mow, trim, and treat the lawn for bugs if needed.
- [ ] Check the sprinkler schedule and turn it off for the party.
- [ ] Buy drinks, ice, and paper goods.
- [ ] Test string lights and extension cords.

The week of

- [ ] Watch the forecast and decide on the tent or rain plan.
- [ ] Give the final headcount to the caterer.
- [ ] Prep make-ahead food.
- [ ] Mark delivery spots and clear paths for rentals.
- [ ] Set up coolers and ice plan.
- [ ] Prepare a cleanup plan and trash bags.

Day of

- [ ] Set up tables and chairs at least 2 hours before guests arrive.
- [ ] Test lighting and music.
- [ ] Put out bug spray, sunscreen, and water.
- [ ] Check restrooms and supplies.
- [ ] Keep food covered and cold until serving.
- [ ] Greet guests and relax.

After

- [ ] Bag trash and recycling promptly.
- [ ] Stack rentals as instructed for pickup.
- [ ] Check the lawn for litter, glass, and decorations.
- [ ] Thank neighbors with a note or small treat.
- [ ] Send photos and thank-yous.

PART 4

Tent, Shade, Power, and Lighting

TENT AND SHADE

- [ ] Decide if you need a tent for rain, sun, or both.
- [ ] Choose a tent size based on the table layout.
- [ ] Ask about staking vs weights if you have a patio or concrete.
- [ ] Check overhead trees and wires.
- [ ] Plan shade for the food table and older guests.
- [ ] Consider umbrellas or pop-up canopies for smaller areas.

POWER

- [ ] Identify outlets and which circuit breakers they use.
- [ ] Avoid overloading circuits with coolers, speakers, and lights.
- [ ] Use outdoor-rated extension cords.
- [ ] Tape or cover cords to prevent tripping.
- [ ] Plan battery or solar options for lighting.
- [ ] Know where the breaker panel is.

LIGHTING

- [ ] String lights over the eating area.
- [ ] Path lights for steps and gates.
- [ ] Lanterns or candles in safe containers.
- [ ] Lighting near the bar and food area.
- [ ] Bug-repelling candles or fans.
- [ ] A flashlight or two for emergencies.

PART 5

Restrooms, Neighbors, and Parking

RESTROOMS

- [ ] Plan on one restroom per 25 to 30 guests for a short party, and more for longer events.
- [ ] Stock extra toilet paper, soap, and hand towels.
- [ ] Mark the path to the indoor bathroom.
- [ ] Consider a portable restroom for 50 or more guests.
- [ ] Add a trash can and a small light.

NEIGHBORS

- [ ] Tell neighbors about the date and hours.
- [ ] Share your phone number in case of concerns.
- [ ] Know your local noise rules and quiet hours.
- [ ] Point speakers away from neighbors' homes.
- [ ] Keep the party to the agreed end time.

PARKING AND ARRIVAL

- [ ] Check street parking rules and any permits.
- [ ] Reserve a driveway spot for deliveries and vendors.
- [ ] Share parking tips and rideshare options.
- [ ] Create a clear pathway from the street to the yard.
- [ ] Set up signage for the gate or entrance.

PART 6

Food and Drink Amounts

Rough guidelines for a 3 to 4 hour party. Adjust for heat, appetite, and the mix of kids and adults.

Item	25 guests	50 guests	100 guests
Burgers, hot dogs, or main proteins	30 to 40 portions	60 to 80 portions	120 to 160 portions
Side salads	3 to 4 quarts	6 to 8 quarts	12 to 16 quarts
Chips and snacks	3 lbs	6 lbs	12 lbs
Watermelon or fruit	1 large	2 large	4 large
Desserts	30 pieces	60 pieces	120 pieces
Cold drinks (cans and bottles)	60 to 75	120 to 150	240 to 300
Water (extra if hot)	2 cases	4 cases	8 cases
Ice	25 lbs	50 lbs	100 lbs
Plates, napkins, cups	50 each	100 each	200 each

PART 7

Rentals Checklist

SEATING AND TABLES

- [ ] Chairs for about 60 to 70 percent of guests at one time.
- [ ] Round or banquet tables for dining.
- [ ] Cocktail tables for mingling.
- [ ] A kids' table with smaller chairs.
- [ ] Lounge furniture for a relaxed corner.
- [ ] Linens in a color that hides spills.

FOOD AND DRINK EQUIPMENT

- [ ] Chafing dishes and fuel.
- [ ] Drink dispensers and tubs.
- [ ] Plates, cutlery, and glassware if not using disposables.
- [ ] Grill or smoker if you do not own one.
- [ ] Extra coolers.
- [ ] Serving utensils.

WEATHER AND FUN

- [ ] Tent or canopy.
- [ ] Patio heaters for cool evenings.
- [ ] Fans for hot days.
- [ ] Dance floor or flooring over grass.
- [ ] Lawn games and a small stage if needed.
- [ ] String lights and pole supports.

PART 8

Cleanup Plan

- Place trash, recycling, and compost bins in obvious spots, with extra bags nearby.
- Assign two helpers to empty bins during the party.
- Keep a small bucket for tableware to avoid scattering items.
- Before the party ends, ask guests to take home leftover food in containers you provide.
- Return rentals clean and dry, following the rental company's instructions.
- Walk the lawn with a bag and a magnet to pick up bits you missed.
- Run the dishwasher or hand-wash glassware the next morning.
- Take down string lights and decor in daylight.

PART 9

Budget Split

Rough shares. Backyard parties usually cost less than renting a venue.



Category	Share	Your budget: $_____	Tip
Food and catering	38%	$_____	Mix catering with self-serve sides to keep costs down.
Drinks and ice	12%	$_____	Buy water and soda in bulk.
Rentals (tent, tables, chairs, linens)	25%	$_____	Order early for summer weekends.
Restrooms and utilities	6%	$_____	Share portable restroom costs if you can.
Lighting and decor	7%	$_____	String lights make a big impact.
Music and entertainment	5%	$_____	A playlist and speaker can be enough.
Cake and desserts	4%	$_____	Cupcakes can simplify serving.
Cleanup and supplies	2%	$_____	Buy extra trash bags and gloves.
Contingency	1%	$_____	Keep a little aside for ice or a last-minute need.

NEXT STEP

Get every rental on one quote

Pick chairs, tables, linens, dinnerware, tents and decor from Chicago-area rental companies and see prices as you build your list at beyondchiavari.com/quote. Want a second set of eyes on your plan? Book a free planning call at beyondchiavari.com/book.

Planning rules of thumb only. Confirm counts, rules and timing with your venue and vendors. © Beyond Chiavari. Free to print and share for personal planning.